WHAT'S ACTUALLY WORKING: AI ACROSS THE ADVERTISING FUNNEL



ALEC FOSTER

Chief Agent Officer & Responsible AI Lead

Marketing + Media Alliance (MMA)

ABOUT ME

Alec Foster

Chief Agent Officer & Responsible AI Lead · Marketing + Media Alliance (MMA)

Today: the think tank work

01 AI TRANSFORMATION

I lead AI transformation at MMA

Global team, 100% trained; 10% staff time allocated toward AI; advanced, responsible AI at scale

02 AI-MARKETING FRONTIER

I co-lead the AI Leadership Think Tank

Frontier experiments: AI tested inside live campaigns, with 300+ marketing and AI leaders

03 AI PRODUCT

I build AI systems for MMA staff and members

MAVEN; our Claude context layer, Marketing Truths; a RAG on 10k+ marketing studies, and more

EDUCATION

M.St., AI Ethics and Society, University of Cambridge · B.Sc., Media, Culture, and Communication and Politics, NYU

linkedin.com/in/alecfoster

CREDENTIALS

CIPP/US privacy professional · Dissertation on governing AI agent protocols (MCP, A2A)

alecfoster.com

BEFORE MMA

Google Ad Exchange policy · Founder, Student Net Alliance · Founder, Ethical Marketing Inc.

mmaglobal.com/ai

ABOUT MMA

A global, CMO-led alliance that tests AI with real brands

Marketing + Media Alliance (MMA) helps marketers prove what drives growth. Our labs test AI with real brands, mostly in live campaigns against a control.



825+ member companies

16+ countries

4 think tanks

ALTT	MATT	MOSTT	DATT
AI Leadership	Attribution	Org Strategy	Data & CX

AWARD-WINNING THINK TANKS AND LABS, 2026

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/awards-and-recognition

- **ESOMAR · Gold** — Breakthrough Research Methodology
- **ESOMAR · Silver** — Excellence in AI and Automation in Market Research (CAP, with AT&T)
- **AdExchanger Awards** — Best Data Technology (Vidmob and Kellanova)
- **Power of Associations · Gold** — Power of Industry/Professional Advancement (CAP)

MY ARGUMENT

THE BIGGEST AI WINS CAME FROM MATCHING THE MESSAGE TO THE MOMENT.

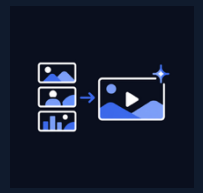
Deciding who sees which ad, when, and where drove our largest lifts, often with ads the brand already had. Making ads with GenAI makes it quicker to launch campaigns, but it hasn't shown the same gains yet.



HOW OUR LABS FIT TOGETHER

Six AI labs, one loop: create, evaluate, optimize

CREATE



A3
Agentic AI Advertising

AI agents take a brief to a finished video

Partner: Monks

EVALUATE

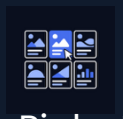


ACE
AI Creative Effectiveness

Score creative before you spend on it

Partner: Vidmob

OPTIMIZE



CAP
Consortium for AI Personalization

Picks the version each person sees

Partner: Claritas



AURA
AI Uncovering Responsive Audiences

Funds the audiences that respond

Partner: Claritas



MOCA
Motivational and Contextual Alignment

Aligns delivery to the ad's motive

Partners: RMT Labs, Wharton

what we learn feeds the next round

OTHER ALTT LAB



GASP
Gen AI Search Performance

How AI answers describe your brand

Partner: Bodhium Labs, Wharton

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/ai

Read the label before the number

A '+40%' can come from a live test or from a forecast.
They don't deserve the same trust.

		How much weight it can carry
IN-MARKET TEST	AI against a control group, in the same live campaign	
BRAND SURVEY	What people in each group told a survey, inside a live test	
PILOT	A live campaign without a clean or published control	
MODEL	A prediction or simulation built on past data	
PRETEST	How people rated ads before they ever ran	



Ask of any AI number: compared with what? Which KPI? Over what period?

OPTIMIZE

SAME ADS, BETTER DECISIONS





CAP

Consortium for AI Personalization

29 experiments

18 brands

4 countries

TECHNOLOGY PARTNER

Claritas

Power of Associations 2026 · Gold
ESOMAR 2026 · Silver, with AT&T

AI chooses which approved version of an ad each person sees, then learns from the campaign's KPI.

- ✓ Our longest-running lab, since 2022
- ✓ Every experiment runs against a control in the same campaign
- ✓ Display, video, audio, and CTV; KPIs from site visits to sales and brand lift

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/cap

Hold the ads constant. Let AI pick the version.



SF Giants (MLB): 6 of 36 versions

learns from the KPI

AI picks a version per impression

Control: the same versions, rotated at random

Campaign KPI

Both groups draw from the same approved creative pool

3 themes × 3 images × 2 headlines × 2 CTAs = 36 versions

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/cap

Big lifts, each measured on something different

KROGER

+259% IN-MARKET TEST

webpage visits

Transactions, not optimized for: +17%

AT&T

+272% IN-MARKET TEST

buy-flow conversions

Matched to AT&T sales data: +88%

SHELL

+161% IN-MARKET TEST

UK app registrations

90 mobile display versions

MLB

+65% IN-MARKET TEST

ticket orders

Average of 7 clubs, 23% to 133%

Each result: AI-chosen versions vs. the same versions at random, in the same campaign. Learn more: mmaglobal.com/cap

Three patterns behind the biggest lifts



1. Enough conversions to learn from

With many versions and few conversions, the AI can't tell what's working.



2. A KPI the ads can move

An $18 ticket moves faster than a new car or a new phone plan.



3. Versions that actually differ

Small variations on one banner theme give the AI little to choose from.

Fast isn't enough: pick a KPI you've checked against sales.

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/cap

CAP · GMC SIERRA

AI optimization moved brand opinion, too

+8.7 pts BRAND SURVEY

brand favorability

+10.2 pts BRAND SURVEY

brand perceptions

+7.9 pts BRAND SURVEY

purchase intent (top two box)

✓ Halo check: Chevrolet Silverado also rose. Rival trucks didn't.

$ Estimated media cost: $0.25 to $0.33 per additional person influenced, at ~$10 CPM

AI-on vs. AI-off · same ads · 1,000+ surveys per group · significant at 95% / 95% / 90%

Presented at POSSIBLE 2026. Learn more: mmaglobal.com/cap



AURA

AI Uncovering Responsive Audiences

AI finds the audience groups that respond to a campaign and moves budget toward them every week. The creative stays the same.

- ✓ About 80% of spend with the AI, 20% business as usual for comparison
- ✓ At least 10 million impressions over four to six weeks
- ✓ Early pilots now; recruiting brands

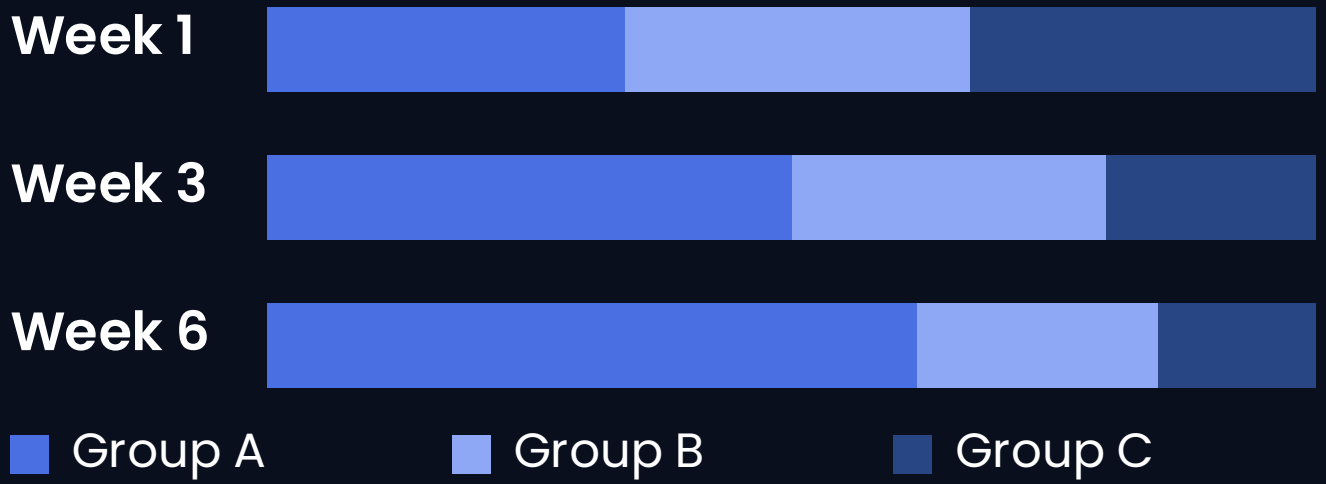
TECHNOLOGY PARTNER

Claritas

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/aura

Move the budget and leave the creative alone

Illustrative weights



Same total audience, same creative.
Budget shifts weekly.

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/aura

22% PILOT

average lift in early pilots

15–25% MODEL

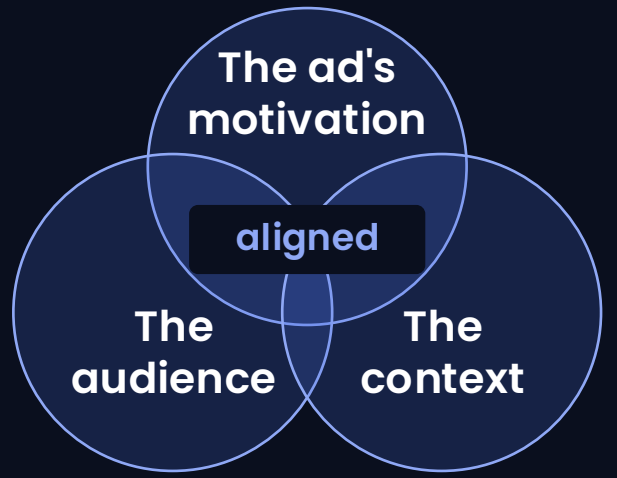
simulated lift on 1,000+ past campaigns

Likely to buy is not the same as moved by the ad.

MOCA: does matching the motivation make an ad work harder?

NEW LAB

Do ads perform better when the audience and the moment match the motivation already in the creative?



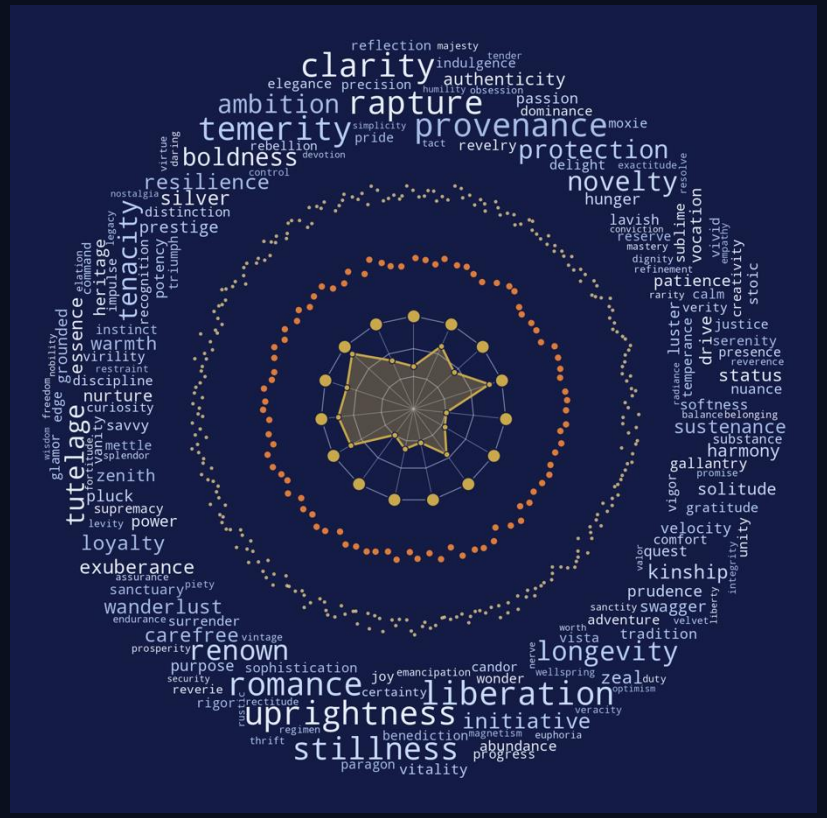
1. Tag the motivations in your existing ads
2. Score audiences and contexts for the same motivations
3. Run aligned delivery vs. business as usual
4. Compare on the brand's KPI

Same creative, budget, and dates in both groups · 8 to 12 weeks

Partners: RMT Labs, Wharton Neuroscience Initiative

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/moca

One motivational language for the ad, the audience, and the moment



100M+	observed choices
265	value signals
87	need states
16	core motivations

SAME THEME, DIFFERENT MOTIVATION

Two achievement ads: one about discipline and precision, one about ambition and legacy. Each fits different people and different shows.

Taxonomy and image: RMT Labs, rmtlabs.ai · Learn more: mmaglobal.com/moca

EVALUATE

SCORE CREATIVE BEFORE YOU SPEND





ACE

AI Creative Effectiveness

AI learns which creative traits go with strong results for your brand, then scores new ads before they run.

- ✓ Import past ads and their results
- ✓ Find the traits that predict performance
- ✓ Score new creative and suggest fixes

TECHNOLOGY PARTNER

Vidmob

AdExchanger Awards 2026 · Best Data Technology (Vidmob and Kellanova)

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/ace

ACE · KROGER × VIDMOB

Kroger trained a creative score on its own ads

1. **1,934 Kroger ads on Meta and Google DV360**
2. **A model learns from a year of results**
3. **Tested on data it had never seen**

MODEL

81%

accuracy sorting high vs. low converters

MODEL

Up to **2.2×**

as many conversions at the same spend, if Meta budget shifts to high-scoring ads



Example: a relatable human moment



Example: people enjoying the moment

MMA, Kroger, and Vidmob, Sept. 2026. Learn more: mmaglobal.com/ace

CREATE

AI CAN MAKE THE AD. DOES IT WORK?



Agents can take a brief to a finished video



Brief → Concept → Script → Storyboard → Video

What we measure: speed, cost, brand fit, and expected performance

Reported by others using AI video

TAXFIX, WITH GOOGLE VEO
Video ads: 6–8 weeks down to a few days

HATCH, WITH MONKS
Costs 97% below legacy production

Self-reported by the brand and agency

Where generated video fits

WORKS WELL
Product demos and animated diagrams

HARDER
A synthetic person in a 30-second story

VARIES BY
Product, category, and brand voice

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/a3

OUTSIDE STUDY · IPSOS × SYRACUSE UNIVERSITY, MAY 2026

AI held up on product-led ads. The best human story won by 65 points.

Creative Effect Index · selected pairs: AI's strongest results and the top human ad

PRETEST



Febreze, AI: 147



Chewy, human: 180



AI version (human score not reported)

+14% human ads' average edge, short-term effect index

+17% human edge, long-term equity index

20 ads, 10 brands, 3,000 US consumers · AI versions made from each human ad's reverse-engineered brief · zero human post-production

Ipsos and Syracuse University, "AI Ads Are Good Enough, and That's the Problem," May 2026

AEO

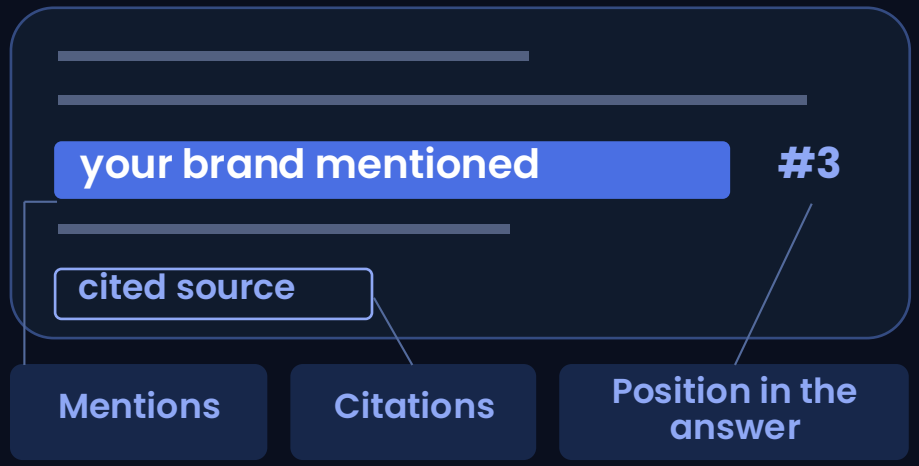
BEYOND THE AD FUNNEL



GASP: can you change what AI answers say about you?

NEW LAB

When shoppers ask ChatGPT, Muse, Claude, or Gemini what to buy, can changes to your own pages raise how often you're named and cited?



1. **Pick real buyer questions**
2. **Baseline the AI answers: weeks 1–4**
3. **Change some pages, leave others alone: weeks 5–7**
4. **Compare through month 3**

Same questions, same AI models, comparison pages left alone

Research partner: Prof. Kartik Hosanagar (Wharton) and Bodhium Labs

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/gasp

Inside GASP: find the gaps, write for them, measure

1. **Find the gaps**
   Track the questions daily across AI engines; spot topics where the brand trails rivals
2. **Draft and simulate**
   Bodhium drafts pages; a simulator tests about 50 versions and keeps the most citable
3. **Review and publish**
   The brand edits for voice and publishes on the treated topics only
4. **Measure**
   Mentions, citations, and position against the untouched holdout

Learn more: mmaglobal.com/gasp

Early signals from Bodhium clients

#27 → top 10
one brand's rank in AI answers

60 questions
cited a single article as their source

10 days
to a new brand's first ChatGPT citation

Reported by Bodhium Labs on mmaglobal.com/gasp

WHAT DIDN'T WORK

Why some tests fell short

1 · SETUP NOBODY CHECKED

An ad platform's default auto-optimization overrode the AI for a whole pilot.

Walk through every setting before launch.

2 · A KPI THAT DIDN'T TRACK SALES

A platform-reported metric showed a big lift. Sales did not move.

Check the KPI against sales first.

3 · NOTHING TO CHOOSE FROM

Every version had the same color, voice, and look, so the AI had little to learn.

Make versions that really differ.

4 · A TEST THAT ENDED EARLY

A data feed arrived late, the flight shrank, and the sponsor left.

Lock the brief, the data, and the sponsor.

YOUR NEXT EXPERIMENT

Design your next test around one decision

Decision

Pick one: audience, version choice, creative score, production, or discovery

Comparison

What does the control do? Same ads in both groups?

Success rule

One KPI you've checked against sales, and a threshold set before launch

Hold constant

Creative, budget, dates: everything you aren't testing

Economics

Tech, production, media, and team time, next to the lift

Owner

One person who decides to scale or stop

Before launch

☐ Asset rights ☐ Explainable data use ☐ Supportable claims ☐ Human review ☐ Stop condition

JOIN THE ALLIANCE

Want to run one of these?

The biggest wins came from matching the message to the moment, often with ads the brand already had.

1 Explore the technology

Consider these vendors (or any alternative): Claritas, Vidmob, Monks, Bodhium Labs, RMT Labs.

2 Run a measured study with MMA

A real control and independent measurement, with results you can take to your CFO.

membership@mmaglobal.com

3 Join MMA

mmaglobal.com/join-the-alliance

Check if your company is a member: mmaglobal.com/user/check-membership

alec@mmaglobal.com

MAICON FORWARD

ALEC FOSTER

Chief Agent Officer & Responsible AI Lead

Marketing + Media Alliance (MMA)

THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.

Q&A

APPENDIX



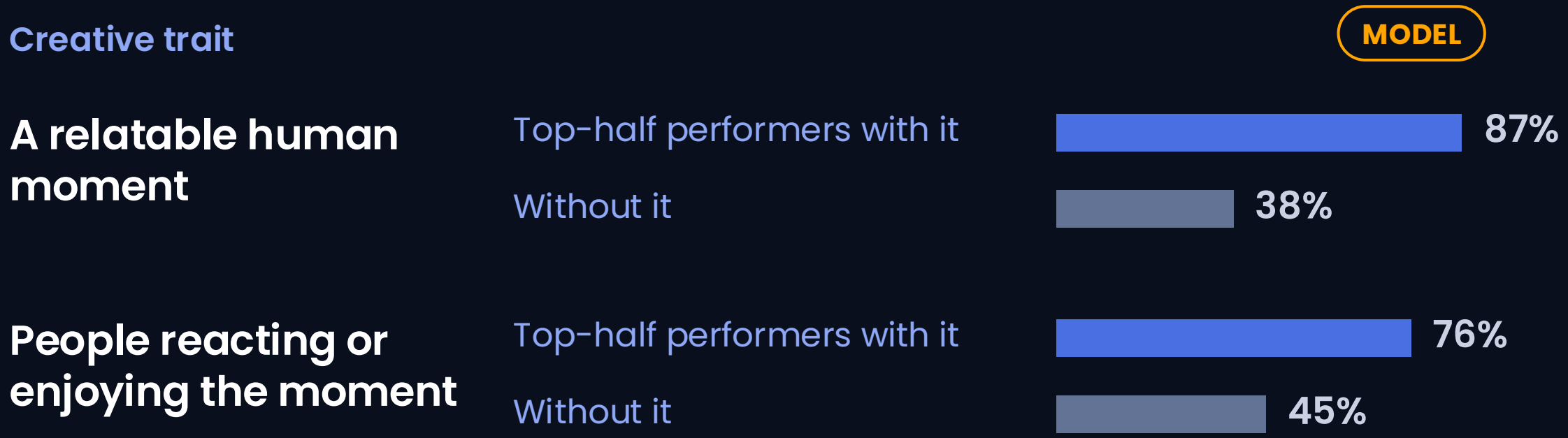
CAP PUBLIC CASE TABLE

Public CAP results, with the KPI each one measured

Brand	Result	KPI	Media	Versions
Kroger	+259%	Webpage visit	Display	72
ADT	+136%	Web form submit	Display	81
GM	+68%	Webpage visit	Video	15
monday.com	+188%	Website visit & app install	Audio	16
Shell	+161%	App registrations (UK)	Display	90
Progressive	+197%	Quote starts (AI audio plus AI optimization)	Audio	96
MLB	+65% average	Ticket orders	Display	2,000+

Each row is its own experiment with its own comparison; don't average them. Learn more: mmaglobal.com/cap

Creative traits that went with Kroger's top performers on Meta



MMA, Kroger, and Vidmob, 2026. An association in past campaign data, not a test.